

Chapter Eight

The Cost of Knowing

The police arrived seven minutes after Adam called.

Nora counted each one.

Not on purpose. Time had become strange since the jumps began, elastic when she was inside another life and brutally exact when she returned to her own. Seven minutes could contain a lifetime. Seven minutes could contain a woman trying to survive the person who claimed to love her.

She stayed on the kitchen floor while Adam opened the apartment door.

Voices filled the hallway.

A neighbor speaking too quickly.

A man protesting.

Claire crying.

The sound moved through the wall and under Nora's skin. She felt it in the place where Claire's fear had left its mark. Her own arm ached where Claire's had been grabbed, though when Nora looked, there was no bruise.

That seemed unfair.

Pain should leave proof.

Adam returned and crouched beside her. His face was pale, but steady in the way he made himself steady when everything around him was not.

"They're talking to her," he said.

Nora pushed herself upright. "Is she safe?"

"For now."

"For now isn't enough."

“I know.”

The words were gentle, but his eyes flicked toward the wall.

The police were asking Claire questions. Nora could hear fragments.

Did he hit you?

Do you want medical attention?

Has this happened before?

Claire’s answers were too soft to make out.

But Nora knew.

She knew the answer to the last question. Not because Claire had said it. Because Nora had been inside the terrible familiarity of her body. Claire’s fear had not been surprised. It had been practiced. It knew the shape of the room, the distance to the door, the difference between his first voice and his dangerous one.

Nora gripped the edge of the table and stood.

Adam rose with her. “Careful.”

“I need to tell them.”

“No.”

The answer came too fast.

Nora stared at him.

Adam softened his voice. “No. Not like that.”

“She’s going to minimize it.”

“You don’t know that.”

“Yes, I do.”

“You know what you felt.”

“I know what happened.”

Adam's jaw tightened. "You know what happened while you were inside her. But you can't tell the police that."

"Why not?"

"Nora."

"Why not?"

"Because saying you entered your neighbor's body during an assault will not help Claire. It will make this about you."

The words struck cleanly.

Nora stepped back.

Adam looked as if he hated having said it.

But he was right.

That made it worse.

Through the open apartment door, a police officer's voice carried down the hall. Calm. Professional. Almost bored.

"Ma'am, without a statement, there's only so much we can do."

Nora turned toward the sound.

Adam caught her hand before she moved.

"You heard that," she said.

"I did."

"She's scared."

"I know."

"They'll leave, and he'll come back."

"We don't know that."

"Adam."

He closed his eyes briefly.

The hallway went quiet for a moment. Then Claire spoke, barely audible.

“I don’t want trouble.”

Nora felt the sentence like a hand around her throat.

I don’t want trouble.

As if trouble had not already entered her home and broken her lamp.

As if survival were impolite.

Nora pulled her hand free and walked into the hallway.

Adam followed, but did not stop her.

Claire stood outside apartment 4B wrapped in a cardigan too thin for the cold corridor. Her cheek was red. One sleeve had slipped down her shoulder. A female officer stood near her, notebook in hand. Two other officers were speaking to the man at the far end of the hall.

He looked smaller now.

That was the part that angered Nora most.

In Claire’s living room, he had seemed large enough to block the world. In the hallway, under fluorescent light and witnesses, he looked ordinary. A man in a dark jacket with his hands raised, explaining himself.

Ordinary men could do terrible things and still look ordinary afterward.

Claire saw Nora and stiffened.

Nora stopped at once.

She had forgotten that Claire did not know her.

Not really.

They were neighbors in the thinnest sense. Nods by the mailboxes. A borrowed screwdriver once. A package held at Christmas. Claire had always seemed quiet, pleasant, a little tired.

Nora had not known the weather inside her walls.

No one did.

The female officer looked at Nora. “Do you live here?”

“Next door,” Nora said.

“Did you witness anything?”

The question opened in front of her like a trap.

Yes.

No.

Not in any way the law would accept.

Adam stepped beside her, close but not touching.

Nora looked at Claire.

Claire’s eyes were frightened, embarrassed, pleading and guarded at once. She was begging not to be exposed, even while part of her begged to be saved.

Nora heard Maya’s voice from the garden.

Useful without invading.

She took a breath.

“I heard screaming,” Nora said. “I heard her say, ‘Please, just leave.’ Then I heard a crash.”

The officer wrote it down.

“And you called emergency services?”

“My fiancé did.”

Adam nodded.

Claire looked down at the floor.

Nora wanted to tell her: I know. I know what he did. I know you are scared. I know this has happened before.

But that knowledge had been stolen by circumstance, not offered.

So she said only, “You don’t have to decide everything tonight.”

Claire’s eyes lifted.

The officer glanced at Nora, but did not interrupt.

Nora continued, carefully, “But you don’t have to protect the version of him that only exists when other people are watching.”

Claire’s face changed.

Just slightly.

The man at the end of the hall turned. “What did she say?”

One officer stepped in front of him. “Sir, stay where you are.”

Nora’s pulse hammered, but she kept her eyes on Claire.

Claire began to cry again.

Not loudly.

Not dramatically.

Just a few tears slipping down a face too exhausted to hold them.

The female officer’s voice softened. “Claire, do you want him removed from the apartment tonight?”

Claire looked toward the man.

He shook his head once.

A warning disguised as disbelief.

Nora saw it.

Adam saw it too.

So did the officer.

Claire wrapped her cardigan tighter around herself.

Then she whispered, “Yes.”

The hallway went very still.

The man’s face hardened. “Claire.”

The officer turned toward him. “That’s enough.”

For the first time, Claire looked directly at Nora.

There was no gratitude in her expression. Not exactly. Gratitude was too clean for this. There was fear. Shame. Exhaustion. And beneath it, something small and stunned.

A person realizing the door was open.

Nora stepped back.

That was enough.

Inside her apartment, she made it three steps before her knees weakened.

Adam caught her by the elbow.

This time, she let him.

They sat on the couch while the hallway filled with procedural sounds: questions, footsteps, the man’s voice rising and being cut down, Claire’s quieter answers, the elevator doors opening.

Nora pressed her palms together.

“They’re taking him away?” she asked.

“For tonight,” Adam said.

“For tonight.”

“I know.”

It was not enough.

But it was something.

Adam sat beside her, leaving a careful inch of space.

Nora looked at that inch.

“I hate this,” she said.

“The jumps?”

“No.” She stared at the floor. “That even when you know the truth, you still can’t just fix it.”

Adam’s face tightened with recognition.

“Yeah,” he said. “That part is awful.”

She looked at him.

For once, he was not trying to soften the world into something manageable. He was sitting beside her inside the awful part.

It felt more comforting than hope.

A knock came at the door an hour later.

Adam looked through the peephole first.

“It’s Claire.”

Nora stood too quickly.

Adam opened the door.

Claire stood in the hallway holding a small overnight bag. Her hair was pulled into a loose knot, and the red mark on her cheek had darkened. She looked smaller than she had through her own eyes. Younger, somehow.

“Hi,” she said.

Her voice was rough.

“Hi,” Nora answered.

Claire glanced between them. “I’m going to my sister’s.”

“That’s good,” Adam said gently.

Claire nodded. Her fingers tightened around the strap of her bag.

“I just wanted to say...” She stopped, swallowed. “Thank you for calling.”

Nora shook her head. “You don’t have to thank us.”

“I do.” Claire looked down. “I kept thinking no one could hear. Or maybe everyone could hear and just didn’t want to get involved.”

The sentence entered Nora quietly.

She thought of all the walls in the building. All the lives stacked close together. All the weather no one named.

“We heard,” Nora said.

Claire nodded.

For a moment, it seemed she might say more.

Then her eyes shifted to Nora’s face, searching.

“You knew my name,” Claire said.

Nora went cold.

Adam stilled beside her.

Claire’s brows drew together. “When you were on the floor. After. I heard you say it.”

Nora could not speak.

Adam answered carefully. “I might have said it. From the mailbox labels.”

Claire looked at him.

Then at Nora.

She did not believe him.

Not completely.

But she was too tired to challenge it.

“Right,” Claire said.

The elevator doors opened at the end of the hall. A woman stepped out, older than Claire, with the same eyes and a coat thrown over pajamas.

“Claire.”

Claire turned, and the control in her face broke. She moved toward her sister quickly, almost childlike. The sister wrapped both arms around her.

Nora looked away.

Not because it was ugly.

Because it was private.

After they left, Adam closed the door.

The apartment settled into silence.

Nora waited for him to speak first.

He did not.

That was new.

Finally, she said, “I’m sorry.”

Adam leaned back against the door. “For what?”

“For going into the hallway.”

“You helped.”

“I almost said too much.”

“But you didn’t.”

“I wanted to.”

“I know.”

She looked at him. “Are you angry?”

He took a long breath.

“I’m scared,” he said.

The honesty landed heavily.

Nora nodded.

“I’m scared too.”

“No.” Adam crossed his arms, not defensively, but as if holding himself still. “I’m scared because part of me thought, for one second, that maybe this thing could help people.”

Nora stared at him.

He looked ashamed.

“With Claire,” he continued, “you knew she was in danger. We called. She’s leaving tonight because you knew.”

“Adam—”

“And then I hated myself for thinking that, because this thing is hurting you. It is violating people. It is dragging you through pain no one gave you permission to carry.”

He looked at her, eyes bright.

“But what if sometimes it matters?”

Nora had no answer.

Because she had thought it too.

Not proudly. Not cleanly. But the thought had come.

If she could know when someone was in danger, did she have a responsibility to act?

And if she acted on knowledge she had no right to possess, what did that make her?

The room felt suddenly too small.

Her phone buzzed on the table.

Maya.

Nora picked it up with shaking fingers.

Adam stayed by the door.

Maya's message was short.

Are you okay? Adam said something happened next door.

Nora typed:

I'm okay. Someone needed help. We called the police.

She hesitated, then added:

I didn't disappear.

Maya replied almost immediately.

Good.

Then:

Proud of you.

Nora closed her eyes.

The words should have warmed her.

Instead, they made her want to cry.

Because being praised for not disappearing meant disappearing had become something people expected from her.

Adam moved to the kitchen and filled a glass of water. He brought it to her.

"Drink."

She took it.

This time she did not make a joke about him giving orders.

The water was cool. Real. Hers.

For the rest of the evening, they stayed in the apartment together.

Adam made tea. Nora did not drink it.

Maya called once, and Nora answered on speaker. The three of them spoke carefully, avoiding details they did not know how to hold yet. Maya's father was sleeping. Claire was at her sister's. Nora had not jumped again.

These were the facts.

The facts were safer than feelings.

Near midnight, Adam stood to leave.

Nora walked him to the door.

He hesitated with his hand on the handle.

"Do you want me to stay?"

The question was simple.

It carried too much.

Before all this, he would have stayed without asking. Before all this, Nora would have wanted that certainty. Now everything required permission. Every touch. Every closeness. Every act of care.

She hated that.

She needed it.

"I want you to stay," she said. "But I think I need to sleep alone."

Adam nodded.

No hurt crossed his face this time. Or if it did, he kept it gentle.

"Text me if anything changes."

"I will."

“Nora.”

She looked up.

He reached for her, then stopped himself. “Can I hug you?”

Her throat tightened.

“Yes.”

He pulled her into his arms carefully at first, then fully when she leaned into him. Nora closed her eyes against his chest and listened to his heartbeat.

For one moment, she was only herself.

Then, beneath the comfort, she felt it.

A flicker.

Not a jump.

Not even pressure.

Something smaller.

A trace of Adam’s fear moving against her own.

She stiffened.

Adam felt it and released her immediately.

“Sorry,” he said.

“No.” Nora stepped back, shaken. “You didn’t do anything.”

But they both understood.

Closeness had become dangerous.

After he left, Nora locked the door and stood with her forehead against it.

The building was quiet now.

Claire’s apartment was silent.

Too silent.

Nora went to the shared wall and placed her palm against it.

Nothing came.

No fear.

No voices.

No door.

Just plaster beneath her hand.

She should have been relieved.

Instead, she felt the absence like a question.

Who else was hurting behind walls she could not hear?

Who else was waiting for someone to notice?

She pulled her hand away.

“No,” she whispered to the empty room.

Not because the question was wrong.

Because it was endless.

In bed, sleep came in broken pieces.

She dreamed of hallways.

Doors on both sides.

Behind one door, Maya cried in the rain.

Behind another, Adam whispered her name into the dark.

Behind another, Daniel’s daughter held up a drawing.

Behind another, Anna reached for a son who would never come home.

Behind another, Claire stood between a man and a locked door.

Every door had a voice behind it.

Every voice called for help.

Nora walked down the hallway with her hands over her ears, but the voices entered anyway.

When she woke, the room was still dark.

Her phone screen glowed beside her.

3:17 a.m.

No messages.

No missed calls.

No emergency.

Still, Nora's heart pounded.

She sat up.

The apartment was silent.

Then came a sound.

Soft.

Almost imagined.

A knock.

Not at the front door.

Inside her.

Nora stopped breathing.

The knock came again.

Behind her eyes, a door opened a crack.

And somewhere far away, someone whispered her name.

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Claire looked toward the man.

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The knock came again.

Behind her eyes, a door opened a crack.

And somewhere far away, someone whispered her name.